

# Web Content Format Standards

Meridian Partners LLP

Marketing & Communications Department

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## 1. Overview & Purpose

This document establishes the formatting standards for all web content published on the Meridian Partners website. These standards ensure brand consistency, accessibility compliance, and optimal user experience across all content types.

All content published to meridianpartners.com must conform to the standards outlined in this guide. In cases of conflict between this guide and any external style reference (AP Stylebook, APA, etc.), this guide takes precedence.

These standards apply to the following content types, each of which has distinct formatting requirements:

- Blog Posts - Thought leadership and topical commentary
- Expert Analysis - In-depth analytical pieces with citations
- White Papers - Long-form research publications
- Insights - Short-form pieces for distribution and syndication
- Outside Publications - Content distributed to third-party platforms

### RULE: PRECEDENCE

When this guide conflicts with AP Style or any external reference, this guide wins. Internal house style is the final authority for all Meridian Partners web content.

## 2. Format Comparison Matrix

The following matrix summarizes key formatting differences across content types. Refer to the detailed sections below for complete requirements.

| Element      | Blog           | Expert      | White Paper | Insight     | Outside Pub |
|--------------|----------------|-------------|-------------|-------------|-------------|
| Headers      | Bold text      | <h3> tags   | <h3> tags   | Bold text   | Bold text   |
| Footnotes    | No             | Yes         | Yes         | No          | Yes         |
| Read Time    | No             | No          | Yes         | No          | No          |
| Audio Button | No             | Yes         | No          | No          | No          |
| Download Btn | No             | No          | Yes         | No          | No          |
| Hero Image   | Optional       | Required    | Required    | Required    | N/A         |
| Dist. Image  | No             | No          | No          | Required    | Required    |
| Author Bio   | Short (2-line) | Full        | Full        | Byline only | Full        |
| CTA Block    | Optional       | Required    | Required    | No          | No          |
| Related      | Auto (3)       | Curated (3) | Curated (4) | No          | No          |

## 3. Blog Posts

### 3.1 Purpose & Audience

Blog posts are informal thought leadership pieces written by attorneys and subject matter experts. They are designed for quick consumption and should not exceed 1,200 words. Blogs are primarily consumed on mobile devices and must be formatted accordingly.

### 3.2 Header Formatting

Blog post headers use bold text only. Do not use HTML heading tags (<h2>, <h3>, etc.) for blog subheadings. The page title is the only <h1> on the page. Subheadings within the body are styled with bold text to maintain visual hierarchy without disrupting the heading structure.

#### RULE: BLOG HEADERS

Use bold text (<strong>) for all blog subheadings. Never use <h2>, <h3>, or any heading tag within blog body content. The only heading tag on a blog page is the <h1> title.

Correct formatting:

```
<strong>Key Takeaways for Employers</strong>
<p>Following the recent ruling, employers should...</p>
```

Incorrect formatting:

```
<h3>Key Takeaways for Employers</h3>
<p>Following the recent ruling, employers should...</p>
```

### 3.3 Estimated Read Time

#### RULE: NO READ TIME ON BLOGS

Do not display estimated read time on blog posts. Read time estimates are reserved for White Papers only. Blog posts are short-form content; a read time indicator adds unnecessary UI clutter.

### 3.4 Author Attribution

Blog posts display a short two-line author bio at the bottom of the article. The bio should include the author name, title, and practice group. Do not include a headshot in the blog author block. Link the author name to their full bio page.

```
<div class="blog-author">
  <p class="author-name"><a href="/people/[slug]">[Author Name]</a></p>
  <p class="author-title">[Title] | [Practice Group]</p>
</div>
```

### 3.5 Footnotes

#### RULE: NO FOOTNOTES ON BLOGS

Blog posts do not support footnotes. If a source must be cited in a blog, use an inline hyperlink to the source material. If the content requires extensive citations, it should be published as Expert Analysis instead.

### 3.6 Images

Hero images are optional for blog posts. If included, the image must be 1200x630px minimum and must include alt text. Do not use stock photos of gavels, scales of justice, or generic handshake images. These are prohibited across all content types per the Meridian visual standards guide.

### **3.7 Related Content**

Blog posts automatically display three related posts at the bottom, generated by the CMS based on practice group and topic tags. Do not manually curate related content for blogs.

### **3.8 Call to Action**

A call-to-action (CTA) block is optional on blog posts. If included, use the standard CTA component. Do not create custom CTA HTML for blog posts.

## 4. Expert Analysis

### 4.1 Purpose & Audience

Expert Analysis pieces are in-depth analytical articles that examine legal developments, regulatory changes, or industry trends. They are longer than blogs (1,500-3,000 words), include citations, and are written for a sophisticated professional audience. Expert Analysis is Meridian Partners flagship content type for demonstrating subject matter authority.

### 4.2 Header Formatting

Expert Analysis uses proper HTML heading tags for subheadings. All section headers within the body must use <h3> tags. Do not use <h2> (reserved for section labels like "Related Content" rendered by the CMS template) or bold text for section headers.

#### RULE: EXPERT ANALYSIS HEADERS

Use <h3> tags for all section headers within Expert Analysis body content. Do not use bold text as a substitute for proper heading tags. Heading hierarchy is required for accessibility compliance (WCAG 2.2 Section 1.3.1).

Correct formatting:

```
<h3>Implications for Financial Institutions</h3>
<p>The revised framework introduces three key changes...</p>
```

Incorrect formatting:

```
<strong>Implications for Financial Institutions</strong>
<p>The revised framework introduces three key changes...</p>
```

### 4.3 Footnotes

Expert Analysis requires footnotes for all cited sources, case references, and statutory citations. Footnotes use superscript numbering in the body text and a numbered list at the bottom of the article, placed above the author bio.

#### RULE: FOOTNOTE FORMAT

Use sequential superscript numbers in body text. Footnotes appear in a dedicated section at the bottom of the article, before the author bio. Use the standard footnote component; do not create custom footnote HTML.

```
<sup><a href="#fn1" id="ref1">1</a></sup>
...
<div class="footnotes">
  <h3>Footnotes</h3>
  <ol>
    <li id="fn1"><a href="#ref1">^</a> Smith v. Jones,
      585 U.S. 123 (2024).</li>
  </ol>
</div>
```

### 4.4 Audio Button

#### RULE: AUDIO REQUIRED

All Expert Analysis pieces must include the audio playback button. The audio component is placed immediately below the article title and above the body content. Use the standard audio component; the audio file is generated automatically by the CMS audio pipeline after publication.

```
<div class="article-audio">
  <button class="audio-play-btn" data-article-id="[ID]">
    Listen to this article
  </button>
  <span class="audio-duration">[Duration auto-populated]</span>
</div>
```

#### 4.5 Author Attribution

Expert Analysis displays the full author bio block, including headshot, name, title, practice group, phone, and email. If the piece has multiple authors, display all author bios in the order listed in the byline.

#### 4.6 Images

A hero image is required for all Expert Analysis pieces. The image must be 1200x630px minimum, include descriptive alt text, and be approved by the Marketing department before publication. Abstract or conceptual images are preferred over literal imagery.

#### 4.7 Related Content

Expert Analysis displays three manually curated related articles. The content team selects related pieces during the editorial workflow. Do not rely on auto-generated related content for Expert Analysis.

#### 4.8 Call to Action

A CTA block is required on all Expert Analysis pieces. The default CTA links to the relevant practice group page. Custom CTAs require Marketing approval.

## 5. White Papers

### 5.1 Purpose & Audience

White Papers are long-form research publications (3,000-8,000 words) that provide comprehensive analysis of complex legal or regulatory topics. They are gated content -- readers provide contact information to download the full PDF. The web page displays an executive summary and key findings, with a prominent download button for the full document.

### 5.2 Header Formatting

White Paper web pages use <h3> tags for section headers, following the same heading hierarchy as Expert Analysis. The full PDF download uses its own internal formatting defined in the White Paper PDF Template Guide (separate document).

#### RULE: WHITE PAPER HEADERS

Use <h3> tags for all section headers on the White Paper web page. The page <h1> is the title. Do not use <h2> within body content.

### 5.3 Estimated Read Time

#### RULE: READ TIME REQUIRED

White Papers must display estimated read time. The read time indicator appears below the title and above the executive summary. Calculate read time at 200 words per minute for the full document (not just the web summary). Display format: "Estimated read time: X minutes"

```
<div class="read-time">
  <span class="read-time-icon">[clock icon]</span>
  Estimated read time: 18 minutes
</div>
```

### 5.4 Download Button

#### RULE: DOWNLOAD BUTTON REQUIRED

Every White Paper page must include a prominent download button. Place the button below the executive summary and above the key findings section. The button triggers the gated download form. Use the standard download component.

```
<div class="wp-download">
  <button class="btn-primary btn-download"
    data-form-id="[gate-form-id]"
    data-asset-url="/assets/whitepapers/[filename].pdf">
    Download Full White Paper
  </button>
  <p class="wp-download-note">
    Registration required for download.</p>
</div>
```

### 5.5 Footnotes

White Paper web pages include footnotes for the executive summary and key findings sections. The full document PDF contains its own complete footnote set. Web footnotes follow the same format as Expert Analysis.

### 5.6 Audio Button

#### RULE: NO AUDIO ON WHITE PAPERS

White Papers do not include the audio playback button. The content is too long for audio consumption and is designed for download and offline reading.

### **5.7 Author Attribution**

White Papers display the full author bio block for all contributing authors. If the paper has more than four authors, display the first three with a "View all authors" expandable section.

### **5.8 Images**

A hero image is required. White Papers also require a branded cover image for the PDF download that conforms to the White Paper Cover Template (see Brand Assets library).

### **5.9 Related Content**

White Papers display four manually curated related pieces. The first two should be Expert Analysis on related topics; the remaining two may be any content type.



## 6. Insights

### 6.1 Purpose & Audience

Insights are short-form content pieces (300-600 words) designed primarily for distribution and syndication. They appear on the website as brief summaries and are distributed to third-party platforms including LexisNexis, Bloomberg Law, and the firm LinkedIn page. Insights must be formatted for both web display and distribution compatibility.

### 6.2 Header Formatting

Insights use bold text for subheadings, consistent with blog formatting. Given their short length, most Insights contain zero or one subheading.

### 6.3 Distribution Image

#### **RULE: DISTRIBUTION IMAGE REQUIRED**

Every Insight must include a distribution image. This image is used as the thumbnail when the Insight is syndicated to LexisNexis, Bloomberg Law, LinkedIn, and email newsletters. The image must be exactly 1200x630px (OG image standard), include alt text, and not contain text overlays.

The distribution image is separate from the hero image. The hero image appears on the web page; the distribution image is embedded in the syndication metadata.

```
<meta property="og:image"
  content="https://meridianpartners.com/
  media/insights/[slug]-dist.jpg" />
<meta property="og:image:width" content="1200" />
<meta property="og:image:height" content="630" />
```

### 6.4 Author Attribution

Insights display a byline only -- author name and title on a single line. No headshot, no bio block, no contact information. The author name links to their full bio page.

```
<p class="insight-byline">
  By <a href="/people/[slug]">[Author Name]</a>, [Title]
</p>
```

### 6.5 Syndication Metadata

All Insights must include complete syndication metadata in the page head. This metadata is consumed by LexisNexis, Bloomberg Law, and social media platforms.

#### **RULE: SYNDICATION FIELDS**

Every Insight requires: og:title, og:description (max 200 characters), og:image, og:type (set to "article"), article:published\_time, article:author, and article:section (practice group). Missing metadata will cause the Insight to be rejected by LexisNexis.

### 6.6 Footnotes, Audio, Read Time

Insights do not include footnotes, audio buttons, or estimated read time. If the content requires citations, use inline hyperlinks. If the content is too complex for the Insight format, escalate to Expert Analysis.

## 7. Outside Publications

### 7.1 Purpose & Audience

Outside Publications are articles originally published on third-party platforms (law journals, industry magazines, LexisNexis features, bar association publications) that are republished on the Meridian Partners website with permission. They require specific formatting to comply with reprint agreements and to attribute the original publication.

### 7.2 Header Formatting

Outside Publications use bold text for subheadings. Preserve the original publication heading structure as closely as possible while converting to bold text format.

### 7.3 Reprint Attribution

#### **RULE: REPRINT NOTICE REQUIRED**

Every Outside Publication must display a reprint attribution notice at the top of the article, immediately below the title and above the body content.

```
<div class="reprint-notice">
  <p>Originally published in <em>[Publication Name]</em>,
  [Original Date]. Reprinted with permission.</p>
</div>
```

### 7.4 Distribution Image

#### **RULE: DISTRIBUTION IMAGE REQUIRED**

Outside Publications require a distribution image for syndication back to the firm channels (LinkedIn, newsletters). Follow the same 1200x630px specification as Insights.

### 7.5 Footnotes

Outside Publications preserve the original footnote structure. Convert footnotes to the standard Meridian footnote component format. Do not alter the substance of citations; only reformat for visual consistency.

### 7.6 Author Attribution

Outside Publications display the full author bio block. If the article was co-authored with an external (non-Meridian) author, display the external author name and affiliation in plain text (no bio block, no headshot) alongside the Meridian author full bio.

### 7.7 Original Publication Link

If the original publication is available online, include a link to the original at the bottom of the article.

```
<p class="original-pub-link">View the original at
  <a href="[URL]" rel="nofollow"
  target="_blank">[Publication Name]</a>
</p>
```

## 8. General Formatting Rules (All Content Types)

### 8.1 Title Formatting

All content titles use title case. Capitalize the first and last word of the title, plus all major words. Do not capitalize articles (a, an, the), coordinating conjunctions (and, but, or), or prepositions of three or fewer letters unless they are the first or last word.

#### RULE: TITLE CASE

Use title case for all content titles across all content types. This supersedes AP headline style, which uses sentence case. Meridian Partners house style requires title case.

### 8.2 Date Formatting

Display dates in the format "Month D, YYYY" (e.g., "January 5, 2025"). Abbreviate months with six or more letters when used inline within body text: Jan., Feb., Aug., Sept., Oct., Nov., Dec. Do not abbreviate March, April, May, June, or July. In metadata and bylines, always use the full month name.

### 8.3 Attorney Names & Titles

On first reference, use the attorney full name and title: "Partner Jane A. Smith." On subsequent references, use last name only: "Smith." Do not use courtesy titles (Mr., Ms., Mrs., Dr.) unless the individual holds a medical doctorate and is being referenced in a healthcare context.

#### RULE: TITLE BEFORE NAME

Place the title before the name on first reference. Example: "Partner Jane A. Smith advised the client..." Do not insert a comma between the title and name.

### 8.4 Practice Group References

Always capitalize practice group names: "Corporate & Transactional," "Litigation & Dispute Resolution," "Intellectual Property." Use the full official name on first reference.

### 8.5 Legal Citations in Body Text

For inline legal citations (not footnotes), use the following format: case name in italics, followed by volume, reporter, page, and year in parentheses. Example: *Smith v. Jones*, 585 U.S. 123 (2024).

### 8.6 Links & URL Conventions

All internal links must use relative URLs (/insights/article-slug). External links must open in a new tab and include rel="noopener noreferrer". Never use "click here" as link text; use descriptive text that indicates the destination.

#### RULE: LINK TEXT

Link text must be descriptive. Write "review the SEC filing requirements" not "click here." This is an accessibility requirement (WCAG 2.2 Link Purpose).

### 8.7 Oxford Comma

#### RULE: OXFORD COMMA REQUIRED

Meridian Partners uses the Oxford comma in all content. This overrides AP Style, which omits the serial comma. Example: "The firm advises clients on mergers, acquisitions, and divestitures." This rule applies to all content types without exception.

### 8.8 Numbers

Spell out numbers one through nine. Use numerals for 10 and above. Exceptions: always use numerals for ages, dates,

percentages, monetary amounts, and legal citations. Spell out "percent" in body text; use the % symbol in tables and charts.

## **8.9 Prohibited Elements**

The following are prohibited across all content types on meridianpartners.com:

- Autoplaying video or audio
- Animated GIFs in body content (permitted in social media only)
- Stock photos of gavels, scales of justice, or generic handshakes
- Underlined text (reserved for hyperlinks per accessibility standards)
- All-caps text in body content (heading elements may use CSS text-transform)
- Inline styles -- use CSS classes from the approved component library
- iframes from unapproved third-party sources